

The Hansard

A WEEKLY DIGEST OF THE PROCEEDINGS OF THE PARLIAMENT OF THE UNITED KINGDOM

Makerfield returns Burnham, and ends a premiership

The safest of Labour seats changed hands on Thursday, and by Monday morning it had taken a Prime Minister with it. Andy Burnham — Mayor of Greater Manchester, out of the Commons since 2017 — won the Makerfield by-election with 54.8% of the vote, a majority of 9,241 over Reform UK on the highest by-election turnout since

2019; the seat had been vacated by Josh Simons expressly so that Burnham could stand. He was sworn in on Monday 22 June. The same morning, Sir Keir Starmer announced he would resign as Labour leader and Prime Minister, ending months of pressure that Burnham's return had brought to a head — the seventh change of leader in a decade, set in

motion by a single constituency a sitting government did not even lose. Around the earthquake, the Commons kept grinding: twelve divisions, an Armed Forces Bill pushed through report stage on the very day the leader fell, and 2,080 written questions from 235 members, with women's pensions the subject that drew the most members in.

THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST

National Security Bill, New Clause 3		144 – 244
National Security Bill, Amendment 8		143 – 249
National Security Bill, Amendment 13		135 – 258
National Security Bill, Allocation of Time		233 – 94
Armed Forces Bill, New Clause 4		164 – 311
Armed Forces Bill, Amendment 11		171 – 322
Opposition Day, Puberty blockers		112 – 283
Opposition Day, Defence spending and readiness...		294 – 110
Opposition Day, Defence spending and readiness		108 – 307
National Security Bill, Amendment 3		85 – 317
Armed Forces Bill, New Clause 22		74 – 323
Armed Forces Bill, New Clause 11		104 – 391

WRITTEN QUESTIONS, BY DEPARTMENT

Transport	269
Health	243
Defence	180
Home Office	160
Education	143
Housing	141
Treasury	131
Environment	127
16 others	686

THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS

10 Internet: Children · 8 Tax Avoidance · 7 Companies: Registration · 7 Public Sector: Procurement · 7 Department for Work and Pensions: Women against State Pension Inequality · 7 State Retirement Pensions: Women · 6 PE and Sport Premium · 6 Domestic Abuse · 6 Civil Servants: Workplace Pensions · 6 Flood Re

THE FEATURE

The seat that unseated a Prime Minister

The week's set-piece happened outside the Chamber — at a count in Wigan, then at a lectern in Downing Street. Makerfield fell vacant in May when Josh Simons stood down to clear the way for Andy Burnham, the Mayor of Greater Manchester and Sir Keir Starmer's most openly ambitious rival, who had been out of Parliament since 2017. On Thursday 18 June Burnham won it comfortably — 54.8% to Reform UK's 34.5%, a majority of 9,241 on a 58.8% turnout, the highest at a by-election since 2019. The victory did two things at once: it returned Burnham to the Commons, and — because a Labour leadership candidate must sit in the House — it made him eligible to challenge for the leadership. In the end he never had to fight for it. Sworn in on

Monday 22 June, he found the contest already collapsing in his favour: that same morning Starmer announced he would resign as leader and Prime Minister, ending months of pressure that Burnham's return had crystallised, and by the afternoon Wes Streeting, the most plausible alternative, had said he would back Burnham rather than stand. Nominations open on 9 July and close on 16 July; a new leader, and Prime Minister, is to be chosen by 1 September, with Starmer remaining as caretaker until then. It is, by one count, the seventh time in a decade that Britain has changed, or arranged to change, its leader — and the first set in motion by a by-election the sitting government did not even lose.

A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK'S QUESTIONS

Special Advisers: By-elections · Mike Wood, Conservative

What information does the Cabinet Office special adviser HR function hold on whether any special advisers have been seconded or taken unpaid leave to undertake political activity in parliamentary by-elections since 1 January 2026?

THE ANSWER As per the Code of Conduct for Special Advisers, where a special adviser wishes to undertake work for a political party which does not arise out of government business they may do this either in their own time, outside office hours, or under a separate contract with the Party, working part-time for the Government. They may not use annual or unpaid leave for this purpose.

THE RECORD

Every figure checked against the official Parliament record. Compiled from the Official Report, the written question record and the division lists, and rendered to one sheet for the week.